

A Roadside Stand



SUMMARY

The speaker describes a little shack of a fruit stall built onto the side of an old farmhouse and reaching out to the edge of the road. This roadside stall seems to be begging piteously for more than just a handout; instead, it's begging for a little bit of the money that enriches people who live in cities. Gleaming cars rush right by this stand without noticing it at all—or, if they do notice it, it's only to be annoyed by interruption to the pretty countryside landscape: the clumsy signs with backwards letters offering berries and squash and the opportunity to rest and enjoy some lovely mountain scenery. The people in these cars have some cash, the speaker thinks angrily, but if they want to be tightfisted, then they'd better just keep it and drive on. The speaker wouldn't complain that these stands mar the view; rather, they feel troubled by the sad message they read in these stands, which seem to be saying: "We've put this fruit stall up out here in the countryside in order to try to get a little money from the city—to see if it will make us feel like we're living bigger lives, like the kinds of lives we see in the movies, the kinds of lives that the government, we hear, is stopping us from having."

The newspapers report that, in an act of supposed mercy, all these poor folks living in the countryside are going to be collected and brought to live in villages, close to the theaters and the shops, where they'll no longer have to think for themselves. The people who want to make this change, the speaker observes, claim to be benefactors, but really they're predators: they're trying to take away the country people's old ways of being and lull them into a complacent sleep.

The speaker can't stand the thought of how much the country people naively long for bigger, richer lives. These sad folks wait near an open window all day, all but praying for one car (out of the thousands that selfishly drive past) to stop, even if it's just to ask how much something costs. A car did stop once—but only to turn around, churning up the grass in the yard on the way. Another driver asked directions; another asked if the farmer could sell them some gas, to which the farmer angrily replied, "We don't have any, can't you see?"

The speaker can hear the voice of the countryside complaining that the kind of freedom and happiness money is meant to give you can't be found in the kind of cash you make as a rural person. It would be a relief, the speaker reflects, to just put these poor people out of their misery. But when they return to their sanity and reflect on that idea the next day, they ask themselves: how would I like it if someone offered to euthanize me?



THEMES



THE RURAL POOR VS. THE URBAN RICH

"A Roadside Stand" offers a dismayed snapshot of the relationship between the countryside and the cities in early-20th-century America (and, in particular, during the Great Depression, which drove countless people into poverty). In this poem, a speaker looks in despair upon a dynamic in which the rural poor are forced to beg for a little money from the urban rich. Not only has all wealth flowed to the cities, the speaker observes, but a money-grubbing, citified way of seeing the world has infected the rural population, threatening the American countryside and its traditional ways of life.

The poem describes a shabby little "roadside stand" that a farming family has built onto the side of their house, hoping to earn a little money by selling produce to the "polished traffic" that whizzes by every day. This stand, the speaker says, is "pathetically ple[ading]" not simply for a living, but for "city money": a [symbolically](#) loaded kind of cash. To the rural people who set up this stand, "city money" represents a dream of glamor and importance, an opportunity to live the life of the "moving-pictures' promise" (that is, a Hollywood dream). The speaker can only see this longing as a "pitiful" loss of dignity and wisdom.

For things weren't always like this, the speaker suggests. Rural people used to live in an "ancient way," "think[ing] for themselves" as they supported their families with what they could grow. Now, an increasingly urbanized world devalues such ways of life, and even seeks to destroy them.

The "polished traffic" from the cities doesn't take a second look at the farmers' little "roadside stand"; city people don't have much sympathy for, interest in, or understanding of country people's lives. But they do have a sense of what country people might be worth to them, on their own terms. Urban bureaucrats and government officials—"greedy good-doers," as the speaker calls them—plot to "b[uy out]" the farmers' land and "gather [rural people] in" to the cities, offering them ease and comfort in exchange for their independence, their traditions, their land, and their labor. The farmers' "childish" view of "city money," the speaker suggests, means that they're going to be completely taken in by this bad deal.

In the speaker's eyes, then, the life of the countryside might already be doomed. Impoverished rural communities aren't fighting back against the encroachment of urban values and urban wealth. Instead, they've fallen for a false dream of what "city money" might do for them. The speaker despairs over this loss to the point that they find a startling "relief" in the idea of

putting rural people “at one stroke out of their pain”—of simply euthanizing the whole rural population before things can get even worse for them.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-51



THE FALSE PROMISES OF WEALTH

The speaker of this poem feels deeply saddened by the struggles of people living in rural poverty. But they also feel aggravated and frustrated by these rural people's ideas about what getting out of poverty might mean and look like. The American culture that Frost observes in “A Roadside Stand” is at once motivated by money and deluded by fantasies of what money means.

The farmers who set up their “roadside stand” do so in the hopes of squeezing a little big-city cash from the urban drivers who zip past their home. Those hopes aren't merely to do with earning money for necessities (though the farmers are clearly very poor: they don't even have a “gallon of gas” to sell to those few drivers who do stop by). Rather, they're to do with the fantasy of a “lift of spirit,” a kind of buoyant, glamorous new perspective on life that only city money can offer.

The speaker imagines the farmers spelling out exactly what they're hoping for: the life of the “moving-pictures’ promise,” the kind of life they see in the movies. To them, in other words, “city money” offers a dream of glamor and luxury. If they had city cash, they believe, it might make their very “being expand,” turning them into people who feel *bigger*. Their dream of “city money” is a dream of self-satisfaction, confidence, and importance as much as comfort.

The speaker clearly sees this dream as fantastical, illusory, and painfully pathetic. The “trusting sorrow” of the poor people who believe in the “moving-pictures’ promise,” in Hollywood fantasies of wealth, strikes them as tragic. While they're troubled by the rural folks's “childish” belief in such dreams, they're also implicitly critical of the people who implant those dreams: the movies reflect a wider cultural attitude that suggests money is a thing of value and importance in itself.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 3-6
- Lines 14-22
- Lines 42-46



THE VALUE OF RURAL TRADITION

This poem's speaker observes that urban bureaucrats and government officials are just aching to get their hands on the land and labor of rural people: these

“greedy good-doers” are busy cooking up plans to “b[uy] out” farmland and tempt rural populations into the cities. This, the speaker feels, would be a great loss to rural folks. While they'd live in greater comfort and convenience, they also wouldn't “have to think for themselves anymore.” Rural ways of life, the poem implies, have a kind of value that a money-driven society simply doesn't recognize: living close to the land connects people to tradition, to natural beauty, and to a rare independence.

People who live and work in the countryside, the speaker says, are involved in an “ancient way” of life. Farming demands that they “think for themselves,” independently solving their problems in order to carve out a living. This is clearly a difficult life (and one that doesn't bring them any great wealth), but it's an honest one. By contrast, a convenient urban life in “villages, next to the theatre and the store” can only inspire a [metaphorical](#) “sleep”: its ease is numbing.

Country life also puts people in touch with the worth and goodness of nature. The speaker respectfully describes the goods on sale at a little “roadside stand”: alongside tempting-sounding “wild berries,” the farmers offer “crook-necked golden squash with silver warts,” an image that suggests there's real value in a humble squash—a different kind of value than the value of gold and silver coins. Less tangibly, the stand can also offer “beauty rest in a beautiful mountain scene,” the opportunity to be restored by nature's glory.

Urban drivers zip right past these offers without even stopping to notice them. But the rewards of living close to nature, the speaker suggests, are real. It's only a shame that even country people seem to be forgetting the value of their rural lives.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 11-13
- Lines 23-31



LINE-BY-LINE ANALYSIS

LINES 1-6

*The little old ...
... and withering faint.*

“A Roadside Stand” begins with a startling description of a little produce stand that a farmer has set up on the edge of a rural road. This description isn't startling because of the stand itself: the stand is perfectly unassuming, a “little new stand” growing out of the side of the farmer's “little old house.” The [diacope](#) of “little” makes it clear that neither house nor stand feels all that impressive or significant.

Instead, what's startling here is the speaker's *perspective* on this stand. They seem hardly to be able to bear looking at it: it “too

pathetically” begs for just a little bit of “the money, the cash” that “flow[s]” through the cities. The stand’s pathetic, insistent begging leeches into the poem’s very shape. This first stanza kicks off with four rhymes in a row, *shed / sped / pled / bread*, creating a nagging sound that suggests this stand’s transparent pleas for cash aren’t particularly sophisticated either.

Remarking on the stand’s pleas, the speaker observes that “it would not be fair” to say the stand is begging for “a dole” (or share) “of bread.” A “dole” can also refer to money/benefits given to the unemployed by the government, and the phrase “a dole of bread” evokes the poem’s context: “A Roadside Stand” was published in 1936, when the U.S. was in the middle of the Great Depression. Unemployment was rampant, as were charitable breadlines.

However, the speaker is saying here that the stand *isn’t* the equivalent of a panhandler asking for a handout or trying to scrape together enough pennies for a meal. Instead, it’s making a play for something a little more ambitious: some of the “cash” that keeps “the flower of cities from sinking and withering faint.” The roadside stand, in other words, is trying to divert just a little urban wealth its own way.

That (literally) flowery [metaphor](#) of cities as blossoms jars against the blunt, awkward tone of the poem so far. There’s also something jarring in the idea of *money* as the nourishing force that makes these dainty blooms grow—a strange [juxtaposition](#) of nature and finance! There might be a hint of a sneer in the speaker’s voice as they imagine cities as flowers that “wither” if they aren’t supplied with enough cold hard cash, flowers at once delicate and indelicately money-focused.

But the metaphor also suggests that the rural people of this roadside stand might be feeling a little withered, too. They need cash as much as the people of the cities do, but they don’t have access to that kind of wealth; it’s the “cities” that have the real money here.

These first lines thus establish a few points:

- This will be a poem about the contrast between urban and rural lives—and about how money (or the lack thereof) plays into that dynamic.
- This will also be a poem whose speaker feels pretty upset with what they see before them. Their scornful descriptions of the roadside stand’s “pathetic[]” begging and the cash-dependent cities alike suggests that they don’t like the way that money dominates either rural or urban lives.

Frost invents his own form here. This 51-line poem uses long, irregular stanzas, and it’s written in accentual [meter](#) (that is, a meter that uses a regular number of beats—five, in this case, as in “A roadside stand that too pathetically pled”—but doesn’t stick to any one metrical foot, like the [iamb](#) or the [trochee](#)). The poem’s rhymes are irregular too, never falling into a pattern. All

of these choices together make the poem feel conversational, flexible, and sometimes rather wild. That helps to capture the voice of a down-to-earth speaker who will nonetheless come to the brink of despair as they survey the world around them.

LINES 7-10

*The polished traffic ...
... S turned wrong*

The speaker now looks from the shabby little roadside stand to the road whose side it stands on. There’s an immediate and sharp contrast between the “polished traffic” that whizzes by on this road and the stand itself. The stand is stationary and rickety; the traffic is mobile and sleek. [Symbolically](#), the stand and the traffic might suggest kinds of *people*: the rooted rural poor, the mobile urban rich (whose “cash,” remember, the rural folks are hoping for a bite of).

The “polished traffic” differs from the stand in another important way, too: it moves with “a mind ahead,” always looking to, thinking of, and zooming toward the future. The planted stand, by contrast, is staying put right where it is in time as well as space; the “little old house” it’s attached to might as well be a vision from the past.

The stand’s hopes for “some of the money” the cars carry seem doomed to disappointment. The [personified](#) traffic (a [metonym](#) for the people driving the cars) zips past without even noticing the stand. If the drivers notice the stand at all, it’s only to be irritated by the way it “mar[s]” (or spoils) the pretty countryside landscape.

The people in these cars, it’s clear, see the countryside as a nice backdrop for them to drive through, not as a place where other people really live and work. The shabby little stand breaks that illusion. Its “signs with N turned wrong and S turned wrong” speak of its owners’ illiteracy, and perhaps their poverty by extension, reminding the urban drivers of aspects of the rural world they might prefer not to confront. (Notice the way the [repetition](#) of “N turned wrong and S turned wrong” suggests the movement of the drivers’ irritated attention, here: *The N is the wrong way round on that sign—oh, and the S, too. Disgraceful!*)

LINES 11-15

*Offered for sale ...
... and go along.*

Though the drivers don’t even pause to see what the stand offers, there’s substance and beauty in the stand’s wares. The speaker describes the farmers’ produce with respect, and the [alliteration](#) and [consonance](#) of these lines of help to convey the richness of the scene:

[...] wild berries in wooden quarts,
Or crook-necked golden squash with silver warts,
Or beauty rest in a beautiful mountain scene.

Wild berries, golden squash: these things, the speaker's careful [imagery](#) suggests, have *value*. The [metaphorical](#) image of the "golden squash with silver warts" might even suggest a kind of natural, inherent value, different from the value of gold and silver coins. And the [polyptoton](#) of "beauty rest in a beautiful mountain scene" stresses the loveliness and value of the stand's less tangible goods. The drivers wouldn't even need to buy something from the stand to get something out of stopping by: they could just absorb their beautiful surroundings, and find themselves internally beautified and restored by what they see. The speaker isn't comfortable with the stand's "pathetic[] ple[ading]" for city cash, then. But they do see value in the work of the people who run the stands and in the natural beauty of the countryside around them.

The speaker now turns from enumerating the "beaut[ies]" for sale at the roadside stand to spit a few choice words at the drivers who zip past without even taking a look. "You have the money," they tell them in a direct and unflinching address; they have the cash to make these farmers' days. But it seems they prefer to be "mean" (in the sense of "cheap," not "unkind") and "go along" without stopping or helping.

Strangely, the speaker stage-directs their own speech, telling readers exactly how they're saying these lines:

You have the money, but if you want to be mean
Why keep your money (**this crossly**), and go along.

That little parenthetical explanation of tone might hint that the speaker is in fact *putting on* a voice here, saying the words that the farmers of the stand might say as yet another gleaming car hums past on the road. The everyday, [colloquial](#) language here—"Why keep your money" (in other words, "Then go ahead and keep your money!")—supports that idea.

LINES 16-22

*The hurt to ...
... keeping from us.*

Having put on the farmers' voices to criticize the drivers, the speaker now steps away and offers a criticism of the farmers. The problem with the roadside stand, the speaker reflects, isn't that it's a "hurt to the scenery." It's that it's just heartbreakingly pathetic.

The stand seems to speak with the farmers' voices, expressing a "trusting sorrow" that the critical speaker greets with alarm. This "sorrow" isn't born of the fact that the drivers don't appreciate what the farmers do and have. It's an expression of what the speaker sees as a foolish desire. They spell that desire out like a ventriloquist, putting on the farmers' voices again:

Here far from the city we make our roadside stand
And ask for some city money to feel in hand
To try if it will not make our being expand,

And give us the life of the moving-pictures' promise
That the party in power is said to be keeping from us.

These lines suggest that the farmers have fallen prey to a childish illusion. Their roadside stand is a way for them to reach toward a dream of what it would be like to be a rich city person, the kind of person they see in the "moving-pictures' promise" (that is, in the visions of glamor the movies show them). They believe, in other words, that if they were rich the way the people in those cars are rich, they'd live bigger, richer, juicier lives: their very "being[s]" would "expand," and they'd feel fulfilled at last.

They also believe that the "party in power"—the current government—is conspiring to keep these kinds of dreams out of their reach. (Or that's what they hear "said," anyway: they don't seem very politically aware.) Their solution isn't to protest, but to try to get in with the in crowd, to live more like the city people in the movies do. And the roadside stand is their sad little way of reaching toward that dream. (There might even be a [pun](#) here on "roadside stand" suggesting a [metaphorical](#) reading: the farmers are making a stand, taking a position. Perhaps they're making a *last* stand.)

This idea strikes the speaker as poignant and "pitiful." The owners of the roadside stand don't seem to recognize the real value of their wares and their way of life any more than the callous drivers do. Everyone the speaker sees is wrapped up in the same illusion of a glitzy urban life built on a foundation of cold, hard cash.

LINES 23-31

*It is in ...
... the ancient way.*

The disgusted speaker now ponders some developments in the "news" related to the plight of impoverished rural folks like those who run the roadside stand. "It is in the news," the speaker reports drily, that these people and all their "pitiful kin" are going to be "mercifully" relieved of their countryside homes and moved into the "villages, next to the theatre and the store." In fact, they're going to be "bought out"—perhaps by developers, perhaps by the government—and "mercifully" relocated for their own good. (Frost might [allude](#) here to policies from the era when this poem was written: during the Great Depression of the 1930s, government programs encouraged some impoverished U.S. farmers to relocate.)

The speaker does not see such a relocation as a *true* mercy, however, but as the act of a set of "greedy good-doers, beneficent beasts of prey." (Readers can hear the speaker's disgust in that growling, barking /g/ and /b/ [alliteration](#) and hissing [sibilance](#): "greedy good-doers, beneficent beasts.") The authorities who are suggesting such a move, in other words, are doing so only because they think *they* can make money off it. They don't see the rural people as their equals, but as easy

marks whom they can “soothe” into giving up their property and their way of life with the glossy “benefits” of convenience and leisure.

Under the spell of such dubious “benefits,” the speaker imagines, the rural folks will never “have to think for themselves anymore.” Rather, they’ll be lulled into a [metaphorical](#) doze, “sleep[ing] all day” in a stupor of ease. Such a false, blinkered sleep will “destroy their sleeping at night in the ancient way.” In other words, it will rob them of the hard-earned sleep of a person living in the “ancient” rhythms of agricultural life.

These last passages suggest that the speaker is in a mixed, conflicted state of mind about this whole situation. Certainly they see the city people as shallow and selfish, the government as greedy and immoral, and the rural people as naïve and misguided. But they also have a marked respect for rural life, farming, and the countryside. No one in this picture, the speaker suggests, can see what the farmers will give up if they leave their old ways behind for the “benefits” of city living.

LINES 32-38

*Sometimes I feel ...
... farmer's prices are.*

Up until this point, the speaker has looked angrily outward, denouncing all the money-grubbing folly they see in urban and rural people alike. Now, they look in, appearing as an “I,” a character in the story, not just a distant observer: “Sometimes I feel myself I can hardly bear / The thought of so much childish longing in vain,” they say. The thought of the rural people’s innocent trust that money might bring them a more glamorous and expansive life, in other words, really *hurts* them; it’s like watching a child about to get disillusioned about Santa Claus. The speaker can feel the “sadness” of the farmers in their own bones.

They try to share that sadness with the reader, too, painting a picture of the farmers “lurk[ing] by the open window” in “almost open prayer” that someone will stop and buy a quart of berries or a squash. The [diacope](#) of the word “open” draws attention to something [paradoxical](#) about the farmers: they’re both vulnerable and guarded. They wait by the open window, but they’re “lurk[ing],” a little hidden; their prayer for a visit is only “almost open,” perhaps barely restrained by embarrassment.

Their desires are restrained and guarded, too. They’re not exactly praying that they’ll make a million dollars and buy diamonds and furs and cars of their own. They’re just praying for what they see as step one on the road to riches: the “sound of a stopping car” that will announce the arrival of some city money on their property.

The [imagery](#) here doesn’t even present such a stop as particularly friendly. The speaker imagines the farmers waiting for “the squeal of brakes,” a rude and abrupt sound that doesn’t exactly suggest a polite customer. But that “sound of a stopping

car” is all the farmers want and all they can bring themselves to hope for.

LINES 39-43

*And one did ...
... didn't it see?*

Even the farmers’ modest hopes, the speaker goes on, get disappointed. Once, a car “did stop”—but it only did so to “back and turn around” in the front yard, and it “plow[ed] up grass” as it went, leaving an ugly scar. Another car stopped, but just to ask for directions. Most insultingly of all, a car stopped to ask if it could buy a gallon of gas from the farmers.

This last request betrays this car’s total lack of understanding of the farmers’ poverty. To the request for gas, the farmers are forced to reply that they “ha[ve] none, didn’t it see?” (And notice how the speaker uses cars as [metonyms](#) for the city people again: the drivers seem like part of their machines, and just as mechanically insensitive.)

The speaker returns to the stage direction from line 15 here in line 43:

*And another to ask could they sell it a gallon of gas.
They couldn't (this crossly): they had none, didn't it see?*

The [repetition](#) asks readers to think a little more about this particular language. The farmers respond “crossly,” not despairingly or mournfully or even full-on angrily. They’re just *cross*, irritated. This mild, perhaps slightly petty language fits right in with the speaker’s picture of the farmers as childishly limited—and thus supports the speaker’s pity for these constrained, struggling people.

LINES 44-46

*No, in country ...
... seems to complain.*

The speaker sits back and reflects on what the sad plea of the roadside stand amounts to: nothing much. “In country money, the country scale of gain,” the speaker remarks in an [ironic](#) tone, “the requisite lift of spirit has never been found.” In other words, the kind of money one can make as a rural person never quite has the glamor, the thrill, the *zip* of the kind of money the farmers imagine city people possess. The scrapings of cash the farmers pick up doesn’t give them the “requisite lift of spirit,” the kind of buoyant, cheerful freedom that they feel they lack.

At least, that’s what the “voice of the country seems to complain.” The speaker here groups all the farmers of all the roadside stands across all the countryside together, imagining that they hear them complaining as one, objecting to the fact that nothing they do seems to get them closer to the life that city cash promises.

This broad-brush portrait of the country people tells readers something about the speaker, too. It's as if they're so fed up they're just waving their arm over the whole countryside in disgust, diagnosing an entire population, reducing them to a single "voice." This is a broad social critique delivered from a height; the speaker seems to feel set apart from the world they observe, frustrated that no one can see what they see.

LINES 47-51

*I can't help ...
... of my pain.*

The speaker's angry, despairing isolation comes to a head in the poem's final lines. Again, the speaker enters the poem as an "I," a character rather than just an observer. And this "I" has something startling to say:

I can't help owning the great relief it would be
To put these people at one stroke out of their pain.

The speaker, in other words, feels the appeal and the temptation of *euthanizing the whole rural population*. Their despair over the farmers' predicament is such that, for a moment, the idea of all the struggling, impoverished people simply dying strikes them as a "relief" to them and to those people alike.

That shocking idea seems to come out of nowhere, but it's also the poem's keystone. (An early draft of this poem was even entitled "Euthanasia.") The predicament the speaker describes—people in rural poverty deluded by false dreams of wealth—is so painful to them that the thought of simply doing away with the problem "in one stroke" feels tempting to them. Perhaps that's partly because they see the problem as so general. A couple of lines ago, remember, they imagined they heard the "voice of the country" speaking, a single voice made out of countless voices.

Having reached this desperate conclusion, the speaker seems to startle themselves out of their despair. The "next day" after having such thoughts, they say, they "come back into the sane"—an awkward turn of phrase that goes out of its way to present sanity as a bounded place that the speaker has temporarily stepped out of. Perhaps that idea chimes with the position the speaker has stood in all through the poem: they've placed themselves as an outside observer, commenting from a distance on the selfishness of city people and the foolishness and suffering of rural people alike. Now, they return to a group, to the world of the "sane."

From that position, things look different:

And then next day as I come back into the sane,
I wonder how I should like you to come to me
And offer to put me gently out of my pain.

Here, the speaker moves from broad generalizations to a more personal, specific encounter between a "you" and a "me"—between people, rather than between "the voice of the country" and the voice of the city. Readers might take these lines two ways:

- That encounter might come as the speaker's quiet internal rebuke to their own temporary insanity: *How would I like it if someone offered to euthanize me because I was suffering?* In this reading, belonging to the world of the "sane" means remembering that people are people, not monoliths; the imagined, generalized "voice of the country" isn't *real*. The real problem is the suffering of individuals.
- But there might be an undercurrent of genuine uncertainty here! The speaker clearly *is* in pain: all through the poem, they've described feeling that they can "hardly bear" the state of the world. Maybe a little part of them actually wouldn't mind being "gently" put "out of [their] pain."

Thinking in terms of the individual rather than the societal, the speaker is forced to reckon with a complexity that doesn't have easy solutions. Their brief sense that it would be a "relief" to euthanize the suffering rural poor comes from the same impulse that might make a "greedy good-doer" decide to round up all the farmers and shuffle them around like game pieces.



SYMBOLS



THE ROADSIDE STAND

The sad little roadside stand becomes a [symbol](#) for the lives and beliefs of the impoverished rural people who run it. Like these poor farmers, the stand is pretty shabby. It's nothing but a little "shed," with signs out front whose "N turned wrong and S turned wrong" reveal the farmers' near-illiteracy. No one stops to buy produce from the stand, either; it's a cry of hope for a better life that goes unanswered.

Perhaps most tellingly of all, this roadside stand is planted and stationary, rooted in one spot—in marked contrast to the "polished cars" in which city people zip by on the road. The farmers, the symbol of the stand suggests, are *stuck where they are*, unable to move out of their poverty. By the same token, though, they're *rooted* in a way the mobile urbanites can't be. The speaker's pun on making a "roadside **stand**" also suggests that the stand represents a moral or cultural stand, a way of stating "ancient" countryside values. Alas, those values are looking pretty unsustainable and rickety.

Where this symbol appears in the poem:

- **Lines 1-6:** "The little old house was out with a little new shed / In front at the edge of the road where the traffic sped, / A roadside stand that too pathetically pled, / It would not be fair to say for a dole of bread, / But for some of the money, the cash, whose flow supports / The flower of cities from sinking and withering faint."
- **Lines 9-13:** "the artless paint / Of signs that with N turned wrong and S turned wrong / Offered for sale wild berries in wooden quarts, / Or crook-necked golden squash with silver warts, / Or beauty rest in a beautiful mountain scene."



THE TRAFFIC

The "polished traffic" that passes the roadside stand by [symbolizes](#) the urban rich and their selfish, short-sighted attitudes. In spite of the sad little roadside stand's hopes, cars never seem to stop to buy its wares. If they ever *do* stop, it's only to serve their own purposes: to reverse over the lawn, to ask for directions, or to try to buy a "gallon of gas" from farmers who aren't rich enough to have any such thing on hand. The "polish[]" on these heartless cars suggests that their drivers have plenty of money to spare; they could certainly drop a few cents on a basket of "wild berries." But they don't. They're intent on "keep[ing their] money," hoarding what they have.

The traffic's behavior reflects the general attitude of rich urban people toward poor country people: they overlook them, misunderstand them, and (if they notice them at all) are unwilling to help them. The cars' swift, thoughtless movement also suggests that the urban world has its eyes fixed "ahead," restlessly moving toward the future, while the rural people with their "roadside stand" stay rooted in tradition and in the past.

Where this symbol appears in the poem:

- **Line 7:** "The polished traffic passed with a mind ahead,"
- **Lines 36-43:** "the squeal of brakes, the sound of a stopping car, / Of all the thousand selfish cars that pass, / Just one to inquire what a farmer's prices are. / And one did stop, but only to plow up grass / In using the yard to back and turn around; / And another to ask the way to where it was bound; / And another to ask could they sell it a gallon of gas. / They couldn't (this crossly): they had none, didn't it see?"

commonality between these apparently opposed groups: both have false and misguided ideas about value and wealth.

The speaker reveals some of the big differences between rural and urban folks with the [symbolic](#) image of a sad little "roadside stand" from which farmers attempt to hawk berries and squash to drivers in "polished" cars. The stand is stationary and shabby, the cars are on the move and glossy: these images sum up the speaker's initial attitudes to country vs. city. The rural people, the stand suggests, live in poverty, but they're also *rooted*; they make a "roadside stand" in more senses than one, building a literal stand but also taking a stand for their livelihood. The urbanites, meanwhile, are wealthy and on the go, always looking "ahead" to somewhere else, no longer in touch with the ground they drive over or the people they drive past.

Though the farmers make a stand in a certain sense, they're also tormented by longings for what the city people have (or appear to have): a kind of wealth that, the farmers suspect, allows them to live the kinds of glamorous lives they see in the "moving-pictures." This "childish," fantastical idea of wealth is part of what makes them set up their roadside stands in the first place. So impoverished that they don't even have a "gallon of gas" to spare, they dream not just of financial security but of a different kind of life altogether.

The urbanites, meanwhile, would like nothing more than to give the rural people the new lives they crave—or some illusion of those lives. "Greedy good-doers," the speaker acidly observes, would *love* to move poor rural people into cities where they could soak up their cheap labor. The only price? The "ancient way" of life the farmers live, and their ability to "think for themselves." The cities, in other words, want not to help but to assimilate the poor people of the countryside, overriding old values and virtues with glossy, superficial new ones.

There's a connection between the rural poor and the urban rich, then: both have their eyes a little too firmly fixed on an illusory dream of wealth. This dilemma just about drives the observing speaker to thoughts of putting the farmers (but not, interestingly, the city folks) "out of their pain."

Where Juxtaposition appears in the poem:

- **Lines 1-2:** "The little old house was out with a little new shed / In front at the edge of the road where the traffic sped,"
- **Lines 7-13:** "The polished traffic passed with a mind ahead, / Or if ever aside a moment, then out of sorts / At having the landscape marred with the artless paint / Of signs that with N turned wrong and S turned wrong / Offered for sale wild berries in wooden quarts, / Or crook-necked golden squash with silver warts, / Or beauty rest in a beautiful mountain scene."
- **Lines 18-22:** "Here far from the city we make our roadside stand / And ask for some city money to feel in



POETIC DEVICES

JUXTAPOSITION

"A Roadside Stand" is built around a [juxtaposition](#) between the rural poor and the urban rich. That juxtaposition also reveals a

hand / To try if it will not make our being expand, / And
give us the life of the moving-pictures' promise / That the
party in power is said to be keeping from us."

METAPHOR

The poem's [metaphors](#) help readers to see the world the speaker sees: one of robotic self-interest and beastly greed. At the beginning of the poem, the speaker observes a [personified](#) "roadside stand" that seems to "pathetically ple[a]d" for someone to stop and buy some produce. The stand becomes a stand-in: it's the farmers who run the stand who are pleading pathetically for a little cash, not the stand itself. But their desperation is written all over the "little new shed" upon which they've pinned their hopes.

If they're hoping that a rich city person will stop and buy some of their produce, they're doomed to disappointment. For the people zipping past on the road hardly seem like people at all. Rather than describing the city folks in their cars, the speaker personifies the cars themselves: the "polished traffic," they observe, "passe[s] with a mind ahead." These cars become a [metonym](#) for their drivers: "polished," ritzy, and glamorous people, but ultimately mechanical and heartless ones, too. With bitter [irony](#), the speaker also imagines these people as the "flower of cities," delicate blossoms whose soil needs to be fertilized with indelicate quantities of cash.

The speaker may also be imagining cities themselves as "flower[s]" that "sink[]" and wither[]" if they're not fed a steady flow of money—a metaphor that, strangely enough, associates the out-of-touch city with the living, growing world of the countryside. And living, growing things matter to the speaker. The crops the rural people offer at their stands are the only things in the poem the speaker approaches with real respect. They describe squash as "crook-necked golden squash with silver warts," a moment of [imagery](#) that also metaphorically links a humble vegetable to precious metals. There's real value in these stands, then, but neither the city people nor the rural people seem to fully understand that.

Meanwhile, city people prepare to strip the countryside of value in their own way. Government officials, the speaker observes, want to move impoverished rural folks into town, a move that's meant to be "beneficent" (or kindly and charitable) but to the speaker looks more like the action of "beasts of prey." The people who want to take rural folks away from their "ancient" traditions, the speaker feels, really want to devour them, eating up their labor and their way of life alike.

The speaker doesn't quite feel that country people are alert to the dangers here. The "voice of the country," collectively, only seems to "complain" that the country folks aren't getting a bite of the wealth the city people have. This broad metaphorical generalization, which transforms all rural people into one "voice," reflects the speaker's own limitations—limitations they

acknowledge at the end of the poem, when they realize that their frustrated wish to put all the poor rural people "out of their pain" is dehumanizing in itself.

Where Metaphor appears in the poem:

- **Line 3:** "A roadside stand that too pathetically pled,"
- **Line 6:** "The flower of cities"
- **Line 7:** "The polished traffic passed with a mind ahead,"
- **Line 12:** "crook-necked golden squash with silver warts"
- **Line 27:** "beneficent beasts of prey"
- **Line 30:** "by teaching them how to sleep they sleep all day"
- **Line 46:** "so the voice of the country seems to complain"

REPETITION

[Repetitions](#) give the poem emphasis and drama starting from the very first line, where the speaker describes a "little old house [...]" with a "little new shed" built in front of it. That moment of [diacope](#) stresses how piteously small and shabby the titular "roadside stand" is. Though it's "new," the shed still seems to share the plight of the "little old house." Both are "little" in two senses: they're physically small, and they're inconsequential in the eyes of the wider world.

There's more repetition in the speaker's description of the signs out in front of the roadside stand, signs written "with N turned wrong and S turned wrong." The [parallelism](#) here feels sadly emphatic, doubling down on the poignancy of these childishly illiterate advertisements.

A later string of repetitions has a more ominous edge. In lines 30-31, the speaker describes how predatory urban "good-doers" want to move all the impoverished rural folks into the cities. Such a move to lazy urban comfort, the speaker thinks darkly, would only rob the rural people of their wits:

And by teaching them how to sleep they sleep all day,
Destroy their sleeping at night the ancient way.

The speaker's [polyptoton](#) here returns to the [metaphorical](#) "sleep" of people who have lost their alertness, their ability to "think for themselves"—and connects that idea to more literal and wholesome nights of "sleeping," of real and hard-earned rest as opposed to dozy inertia.

Another strange, striking repetition presents the poem as a kind of play. Twice, in lines 15 and 43, the speaker inserts what sounds a lot like a stage direction: "(this crossly)." Readers, in other words, are to imagine the words before this description spoken in an irritable, "cross" voice. Compare the two places these directions arise:

You have the money, but if you want to be mean
Why keep your money (this crossly), and go along.

[...]

And another to ask could they sell it a gallon of gas.
They couldn't (**this crossly**): they had none, didn't it see?

In these lines, the “cross” voices of the farmers who run the roadside stand enter the narrative, with the speaker listening in. The stage-direction style here introduces an observer’s distance between the speaker and the farmers, a sense that the speaker is looking in on the happenings at this stand, taking an interest.

The return to the world “crossly” also suggests a certain pettiness: the farmers aren’t despairing or outraged, they’re just irritated, on a small scale that fits in with the speaker’s image of them as “childish” and limited.

The speaker’s own unease with the farmers’ limits and the urbanites’ selfishness comes into focus in the poem’s final grim repetition:

I can't help owning the great relief it would be
To put these people at one stroke out of their pain.
And then next day as I come back into the sane,
I wonder how I should like you to come to me
And offer to put me gently out of my pain.

These lines raise despair only to counter it with empathy. The first time the speaker describes wishing to “put these people at one stroke out of their pain,” they do so with a sense that the farmers don’t have lives worth living. They reject this idea with the realization that it simply isn’t “sane”—and the admission that they, too, are in pain, and wouldn’t like someone suggesting that perhaps *they* should be euthanized. This repetition gets at a sadness in the poem’s core: a push-pull between alienation and empathy, disgust and gentleness.

Where Repetition appears in the poem:

- **Line 1:** “little old house,” “little new shed”
- **Line 10:** “N turned wrong,” “S turned wrong”
- **Line 15:** “(this crossly)”
- **Line 30:** “sleep,” “sleep”
- **Line 31:** “sleeping”
- **Line 34:** “open”
- **Line 35:** “open”
- **Line 43:** “this crossly”
- **Line 44:** “country,” “country”
- **Line 46:** “country”
- **Line 48:** “put these people at one stroke out of their pain”
- **Line 51:** “put me gently out of my pain”

ANAPHORA

[Anaphora](#) supports a tone of weariness in the speaker’s voice, creating moments in which one thing after another *piles up*. An early example appears when the speaker describes what the signs for the roadside stand advertise:

Offered for sale wild berries in wooden quarts,
Or crook-necked golden squash with silver warts,
Or beauty rest in a beautiful mountain scene.

The anaphora here catalogues the things the roadside stands have to offer: small but real treasures that the city people in their gleaming cars have no use for.

Later moments of anaphora feel sadder and more thoughtful:

The sadness **that** lurks near the open window there,
That waits all day in almost open prayer
For **the** squeal of brakes, **the** sound of a stopping car,
[...]
And one did stop, but only to plow up grass
In using the yard to back and turn around;
And **another** to ask the way to where it was bound;
And **another** to ask could they sell it a gallon of gas.

These repetitions register as simply weary. The farmers can lurk and wait all they want, but they won’t get what they want: “another” and “another” stopping car will only disappoint them.

Where Anaphora appears in the poem:

- **Line 12:** “Or crook-necked golden squash”
- **Line 13:** “Or beauty rest”
- **Line 27:** “greedy good-doers, beneficent beasts of prey”
- **Line 34:** “that lurks”
- **Line 35:** “That waits”
- **Line 36:** “the squeal,” “the sound”
- **Line 39:** “And one”
- **Line 41:** “And another”
- **Line 42:** “And another”

ALLITERATION

[Alliteration](#) highlights the outraged and despairing speaker’s tone of voice. In line 3, for instance, as the speaker describes how the roadside stand “too pathetically ple[ads]” for custom, readers might just about hear them spitting in disgust through those two plosive /p/ sounds. There’s similar distaste in the sibilant alliteration of lines 5-6:

[...] the cash, whose flow supports
The flower of cities from sinking and withering faint.

There’s a bitter hiss in this description of cash as the “flow” that

nourishes cities. (Notice, too, the match between “flow” and “flower”—not quite the same sound, but similar enough to feel striking!)

The speaker’s rage comes through yet again when they describe the urban governments who’d like to move impoverished rural people into towns as “greedy good-doers, beneficent beasts of prey.” The blunt, forceful /g/ and /b/ alliteration here adds a flourish to this denouncement, and the [parallelism](#) of this phrasing further stresses the [irony](#): these “good-doers” are really “beasts of prey,” these “greedy” people are not truly “beneficent.”

Alliteration also highlights the speaker’s cry of exasperation and despair in lines 47-48:

I can't help owning the great relief it would be
To put these people at one stroke out of their pain.

A strong /p/ sound makes the speaker’s outburst feel particularly shocking.

Where Alliteration appears in the poem:

- **Line 5:** “supports”
- **Line 6:** “cities,” “sinking”
- **Line 7:** “polished,” “passed”
- **Line 11:** “wild,” “wooden”
- **Line 12:** “squash,” “silver,” “warts”
- **Line 14:** “money,” “mean”
- **Line 21:** “pictures,” “promise”
- **Line 22:** “party,” “power”
- **Line 27:** “greedy good-doers,” “beneficent beasts”
- **Line 36:** “squeal,” “sound,” “stopping”
- **Line 42:** “gallon,” “gas”
- **Line 46:** “country,” “complain”
- **Line 48:** “put,” “people,” “pain”
- **Line 51:** “put,” “pain”

This crossly (Line 15, Line 43) - That is, “these words are being said crossly,” or angrily. This parenthetical works like stage directions.

Why keep your money (Line 15) - “Why,” here, should be read as an exclamation, not a question: the connotation is, “then go ahead and keep your money.”

The moving-pictures (Line 21) - The movies. The “life of the moving pictures” promise” refers to the (in the speaker’s mind, illusory) glamor of Hollywood.

Kin (Line 23) - Family members, relations.

Beneficent (Line 27) - Kindly, well-intentioned. Here, the speaker uses the word [ironically](#): those offering to relocate the rural poor are not generous “good-doers” but rather “beasts of prey.” They’re predators, preying on the poor while pretending to be helping them.

Requisite life of spirit (Line 45) - Necessary thrill. The speaker is saying that “country money”—the kind of money made as a rural person—never feels as exciting or glamorous as the kind of money that city people have (at least, in the farmers’ imaginations).



FORM, METER, & RHYME

FORM

“A Roadside Stand” tells its tale in a flexible, almost conversational form. The poem is built from 51 lines divided into four irregular stanzas, all written in five-beat accentual meter. In other words, the lines consistently use five beats, but they don’t stick to a regular metrical foot like the [iamb](#) or the [trochee](#). The [rhyme scheme](#) is flexible, too: while there’s plenty of rhyme, it never falls into a predictable shape. Instead, it either meanders or insists, moving from strings of four rhymes in a row (as in lines 1-4) to passages in which a rhyme word doesn’t meet its match until many lines later (as in the rhyme between “wrong” in line 10 and “along” in line 15).

There’s a crafted poetic form here, then, but also a spontaneous, shifty, and surprising one. The sudden lurches in the rhyme, the varied lengths of the stanzas, and the steady-but-irregular rhythm of the meter all capture the speaker’s agitated, nervous state of mind as they contemplate the greed and folly of urbanites and countryfolk alike.

Watching urban people drive heartlessly past a pitiful “roadside stand” offering produce for sale—and watching rural people fall prey to illusions of a wealthy life like the one they see in the “moving-pictures”—makes this speaker feel restless and disillusioned. Sometimes, they worry about being driven to desperation by their disgust, knowing they’re not quite “sane” when they imagine putting all the poor misguided farmers “out of their pain.” The poem’s loose but insistent shape and sound help to highlight the speaker’s volatile state of mind.



VOCABULARY

Pled (Line 3) - Begged. The speaker [personifies](#) the stand as piteously begging for passing drivers to stop.

Dole (Line 4) - Handout, share. A “dole of bread” might make readers picture the charitable breadlines during the Great Depression, when this poem was written.

Marred (Line 9) - Disfigured, spoiled. The signs pointing to this stand are ruined by their clumsy lettering.

Artless paint (Line 9) - This refers to the clumsy, unskilled letters on the signs directing people to the stand.

Mean (Line 14) - In the sense of “cheap, miserly,” not the sense of “unkind.”

METER

"A Roadside Stand" is written in accentual meter. In accentual meter, the poet doesn't stick to a single dominant metrical foot (like the da-DUM of the [iamb](#) or the DUM-da-da of the [dactyl](#)), but measures lines out by the number of beats they contain—in this case, five beats a line. Lines 16-17 provide a nice example:

The hurt to the scenery wouldn't be my complaint
So much as the trusting sorrow of what is unsaid:

These lines feel at once rhythmic and naturalistic. The driving five-beat pulse is noticeable, but there's plenty of room in it for a flexibility that makes the speaker's voice sound conversational—as if they're a character in the poem, involved in the world they describe rather than pronouncing on it from a literary height.

The way that Frost lands his stresses here makes the speaker sound a little pugnacious, too. Almost every line of the poem ends on a strong **stress**, a choice that feels bold and even aggressive (especially when it works in tandem with a long series of rhymes, like the *shed / sped / pled / bread* sequence that opens the poem.) One deviation from this pattern comes in lines 21-22:

And give us the life of the moving-pictures' promise
That the party in power is said to be keeping from us.

The falling unstressed syllables at the end of these two lines support the country people's rather sour, crestfallen tone as they describe what they hope they might get out of a few handfuls of city cash.

RHYME SCHEME

While "A Roadside Stand" doesn't stick to a regular [rhyme scheme](#), it does use plenty of rhyme, and often in surprising and distinctive ways. The poem's first four lines, for instance, run like this:

[...] shed [A]
[...] sped, [A]
[...] pled, [A]
[...] bread, [A]

Those four A rhymes in a row (all landing on a strong **stressed** syllable, too) feel blunt and abrupt, maybe even a little clumsy. They thus suit the unassuming, ramshackle "roadside stand" they describe, with its "signs [...]" with N turned wrong and S turned wrong."

Across the rest of the poem, Frost uses meandering and unpredictable patterns of rhyme. Sometimes he'll leave a rhyme word hanging for long intervals—as in the link between *faint* in line 6, *paint* in line 9, and *complaint* in line 16. And sometimes,

he'll insert some punchy rhymed [couplets](#) (like the *hand / expand* and *promise / from us* sequence in lines 19-22).

The rhymes, in other words, are hard to get a grip on. The poem's lurching, evasive rhymes work with the poem's tone of dismay, matching the frustrated speaker's lack of good ideas about how to resolve the suffering and confusion they observe in rural America.



SPEAKER

The poem's speaker looks with sympathy upon the people who live in the countryside and run their desperate "roadside stand"—but they don't seem to count themselves among this population. Yet the speaker doesn't exactly seem to be an urban person, either: they look with disdain upon the people who live in the city, drive gleaming cars, and scorn the roadside stand. This speaker stands apart from both the worlds they criticize. Perhaps they've lived in both.

They certainly seem to be on more intimate and sympathetic terms with rural folks than urban, seeing their way of life as more honest and less shallow than the lives of those who "live in villages, next to the theatre and the store" and don't "think for themselves." However, they also view the rural population with some condescension, observing that the farmers' wistful desire for "city money" is just a "childish longing" and even briefly admitting that they'd feel "great relief" at "put[ting] these people at one stroke out of their pain." That doesn't last long; a moment later, they're asking themselves how *they* would feel if someone offered to euthanize *them*. But it's a revealing, complex flash of horror, pity, and disgust. Perhaps the clearest thing readers can gather about this speaker, then, is that they're a person with a dim view of the whole modern world, from the poverty-stricken proprietors of the roadside stand to the inconsiderate drivers who pass them by.



SETTING

"A Roadside Stand" is set in an unidentified American rural area, a "beautiful mountain scene" whose people are nevertheless impoverished and desperate. Frost never identifies where exactly this spot is; he only contrasts it with the gleaming city, where people live next door to "the theatre and the store," enjoying a glossier but more complacent way of life. (Readers familiar with Frost's work, however, might guess that the poem takes place somewhere in New England, the scene of most of his poetry.)

This scenario feels of a time as much as a place. Frost published this poem in 1936, right in the heart of the Great Depression—a time when desperate American farmers were indeed giving up and relocating to cities, hoping for more work and better lives. The poem's speaker has pained, conflicted

feelings about the countryside. Country people, they observe, live by "ancient way[s]," working for sustenance rather than for the flashy rewards of gleaming cars and fancy lifestyles—and, in the speaker's opinion, they "think for themselves," in contrast to the urbanites seduced by convenience, glamor, and cash. But these country people, the speaker notes, also *want* what the urbanites have, with a "childish longing" that fills them with "trusting sorrow." In other words, they don't know the value of the kinds of lives they lead, and they feel betrayed and abandoned by a world that values the "moving-pictures" promise" (that is, Hollywood illusions about how life should be) above all.



CONTEXT

LITERARY CONTEXT

"A Roadside Stand" was first collected in *A Further Range* (1936), the book that won American poet Robert Frost (1874-1963) his third of four Pulitzer Prizes in Poetry.

Though widely read and much honored during his lifetime, Frost was often received as a quaint, folksy writer: a kind of backwoods New England sage. In 1958, the famous literary critic Lionel Trilling helped change this perception when he called the elderly Frost "a terrifying poet." Though Frost remained steadfastly traditional in his use of [meter](#) and [rhyme](#), he displayed a very modern skepticism—sometimes even a chilling pessimism—in poems like "[Desert Places](#)," "[Design](#)," "[The Most of It](#)," and indeed "A Roadside Stand." Many of Frost's poems, including "Desert Places" and the famous "[Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening](#)," feature solitary characters, rural settings, and explorations of the relationship between humanity and nature.

Robert Frost wrote during the [modernist](#) period of the early 20th century. While his work contains some modernist traits, Frost often stuck to familiar rhythms and meters in ways that other modernists (like [T. S. Eliot](#) and [Ezra Pound](#)) usually did not. Like the modernists, however, he embraced and experimented with conversational diction: he often wrote in New England dialect.

Despite Frost's use of some features of modernism, he never aligned himself with any particular school of writing. He was known for his unique style and his willingness to draw on a variety of poetic traditions. In particular, his focus on the natural world connects his work to an earlier generation of New England writers like [Ralph Waldo Emerson](#) and [Emily Dickinson](#).

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Though he lived through World Wars I and II and saw many significant social and political shifts in his lifetime, Frost hardly ever wrote directly about history or politics. Instead, Frost's

poetry is known for dealing with rural New England life and identity. Frost lived and worked on a New Hampshire farm from 1900 to 1912, and his poetry's focus on rural life, nature, and New England reflects his experiences.

This poem, however, is an exception. Its remarks on "greedy good-doers" trying to "soothe [farmers] out of their wits" might be read as Frost's response to governmental attempts to relieve poverty during the Great Depression. During this worldwide economic catastrophe, American farmers came under strain from tough financial conditions and [tough weather](#) alike. As this poem's speaker observes, many farmers were forced or coaxed to leave their land and their traditional lives and move to cities to find work. Frost here laments the loss of rural rootedness as desperate farmers go in search of "city money." He also casts a wary eye over a government that "enforc[es] benefits" on its people—in this case, an urban government that takes too heavy-handed an approach to "improving" rural people's lives according to its own standards.



MORE RESOURCES

EXTERNAL RESOURCES

- [A Brief Biography](#) — Learn more about Frost's life and work. (<https://www.poetryfoundation.org/poets/robert-frost>)
- [Frost's Home](#) — Visit the website of the Robert Frost Farm, a museum housed in one of Frost's former homes, to learn more about the poet's life. (<https://www.robertfrostfarm.org/>)
- [The Great Depression](#) — Learn more about the Great Depression, the massive economic crisis that was in full swing when Frost published "A Roadside Stand" in 1936. (<https://www.history.com/topics/great-depression/great-depression-history>)
- [An Interview with Frost](#) — Listen to a recorded conversation between Frost and his fellow poet Randall Jerell. (<https://www.loc.gov/item/93842984/>)

LITCHARTS ON OTHER ROBERT FROST POEMS

- [Acquainted with the Night](#)
- [After Apple-Picking](#)
- [Birches](#)
- [Desert Places](#)
- [Design](#)
- [Dust of Snow](#)
- [Fire and Ice](#)
- [Home Burial](#)
- [Mending Wall](#)
- [Mowing](#)
- [My November Guest](#)
- [Nothing Gold Can Stay](#)

- [Out, Out—](#)
- [Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening](#)
- [The Death of the Hired Man](#)
- [The Oven Bird](#)
- [The Road Not Taken](#)
- [The Sound of the Trees](#)
- [The Tuft of Flowers](#)
- [The Wood-Pile](#)



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